

MORGAN QUINN

WRITING CRAFT

CLASS NOTES

The Psychological Engine of Story

CHARACTER PSYCHOLOGY IN FICTION

Two Scenes, One Plot

The same action can carry very different personal stakes.

EVENT ALONE

A soldier receives orders to retreat. He obeys.

PERSONAL STAKES

A soldier receives orders to retreat. His men will live, but his hometown will be abandoned. He obeys. At the crossroads, he turns his horse away from home.

What does obeying cost him? Share a possibility in chat.

Motivation vs. Goal

What they pursue, and why it matters to them.

MOTIVATION

The emotional reason the goal matters: safety, belonging, recognition, loyalty, or something else.

May persist, deepen, or change.

GOAL

The concrete outcome they pursue in a scene or across the story.

Scene goals can serve a larger goal.

A recurring emotional concern can connect very different choices.

The ‘So That’ Chain

Mara wants a promotion. What does she hope it will give her?

GOAL

I want the

promotion

SO THAT

people finally

respect me

SO THAT

(EMOTIONAL MOTIVE)

I can feel

I’m worth something

Then ask: what would she do to secure that feeling?

Mara's Choices Under Pressure

Her desire for worth persists. Her way of pursuing it can change.

OPENING

Mara takes on extra work so nobody can question her value.

PRESSURE

Her boss offers advancement if she takes credit for Eli's work.

POSSIBLE ENDING

She credits Eli and risks the promotion. She acts by her values despite uncertain approval.

Mara and Eli are invented examples used throughout this series.

One Goal, Different Motives

Mara wants the promotion. What might it give her emotionally?

Version A: she wants to feel worthy. What might she do?

Version B: she wants financial safety. What might she do?

Same opportunity: take credit for Eli's work. How might each version respond?

Today's Takeaways

The goal names the outcome. Motivation makes it matter.

Use 'so that' to find a motive, then test it through a choice.

Next session: how experience becomes a protective pattern.